

Games & Fun Pack • Start Here

Games and Fun

Trust your hackles. Pause • Check • Tell.

FIELD COPY

1

hackles up!



Hackle

whose quills stand up when something feels off

2



Latch

LOCK IT

3



Peeper

SPOT IT

4



Pip

SHARE SMART

5



Buddy

SAFE PEOPLE

6



Ember

KIND AND WELL

7



Fixit

FIX IT

PLATE I. The Hackles crew, drawn from life: Hackle (1) and the six friends who look after each strand.

Hackles • a free kit • quillsup.org

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OCTOBER 2026

[Logo: Hackles]

HACKLES GAMES & FUN PACK

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Grade bands: K-2 (ages 5-7) · 3-5 (ages 8-10) · 6-8 (ages 11-13) · 9-12 (ages 14-18)

Status: DRAFT. Items marked [VERIFY] must be checked before publication.

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever. Every game in this pack is unplugged: paper, pencils, a timer, and people.

About Hackles

Hackles was made by a small group of educators and practitioners who believe every child and teen should learn how to stay safe and kind online, and that this teaching should not sit behind a paywall. That is why Hackles is free to print, share and adapt for non-commercial use, with credit. No accounts, no data, and the whole kit is at quillsup.org.

"Hackles" are what rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. Hackles teaches children to **notice that feeling and act on it**: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. A false alarm is fine and welcome. And if the feeling was ignored, or someone was tricked anyway, it is never the child's fault, and the next step is always to tell someone.

We want your feedback: which games your kids begged to replay, which cards confused them, what your families said. [CONTACT: to be added]

Hackles is the first step on a learning path that continues with free resources such as [picoCTF](https://picoCTF.org) and CYBER.ORG.

Welcome: games are how this stuff sticks

You do not have to be a technology person to run any of this. Every game in the pack is scripted. If you can read a card out loud and say "Nice noticing!", you can run it.

Kids remember what they *do*, not what they hear. A child who has held up a FISHY card forty times is a child whose hackles go up at the forty-first real message. A teen who has argued out loud about whether a fake giveaway DM is a scam is a teen who will argue with themselves at 1 a.m. when the real one arrives. Play is rehearsal.

WHAT IS IN THIS PACK

#	FILE	WHAT IT IS	BANDS
1	01_Spot_the_Fishy_Card_Game	Two 66-card decks (K-5 and 6-12) plus rules, scoring and variants	K-12
2	02_The_Hackles_Trail_Board_Game	Cooperative whole-class board game against the Too-Good Box	K-12
3	03_Mission_Quiet_Door_Escape_Missions	12 classroom escape-room-style missions, answer keys included	K-12
4	04_Read_Alouds_and_Graphic_Stories	4 read-alouds K-2, 4 read-alouds 3-5, 3 graphic scripts 6-8	K-8
5	05_Songs_Chants_and_Movement_Breaks	10 original songs, chants, rhymes and movement breaks	K-8 (teen-friendly options)
6	06_Puppet_Show_and_Role_Play_Library	One puppet show script and 20 short role-play scripts	K-12
7	07_Bingo_Passport_Badges_and_Awards	Bingo cards, Hackles Passport, badges, awards	K-12
8	08_Jokes_Riddles_and_Brain_Teasers	30 kid-clean security-themed jokes, riddles, teasers	K-12
9	09_Hackles_Day_Event_Plan	12-station event plan (add-on to the Hackles Day Kit, renamed Hackles Day)	K-12

Every file starts with a one-page "Teacher Quick Start" you can print and keep beside the game, and ends with an "Accessibility variants" table and a "Printables checklist" that names exactly what to print and cut. (Added after the Round 2 playtest.)

HOW LONG EACH GAME REALLY TAKES (SCRIPT-TESTED)

We ran thousands of simulated plays of the games that have rules and counted turns and minutes. These are the honest numbers.

GAME	10-MINUTE MODE	30-MINUTE MODE	WHAT WE FOUND
Spot the Fishy	Quick Catch: 8 cards, Mini Pond of 12 circles, about 10 minutes	Full Pond: 24 cards, Pond (30) plus Lagoon (24), about 30 minutes	The first scoring rule filled the pond in 2 or 3 cards; the Pond now fills in about 13 to 15 cards.
The Hackles Trail	Mini Trail: 15 spaces, about 4 team turns, about 10 minutes	Full Trail: 40 spaces, about 9 team turns, 26 to 33 minutes (Sunrise Wind rule keeps it to 30)	The first version took 33 to 37 minutes, had dead Ladder rules and gave Gold Peak 999 times in 1,000 games. Tiers are now about 70 / 30 / 1 percent.
Mission: Quiet Door	Quick Door: two stages plus the Door ritual, about 10 minutes	Full Escape: four stages, about 30 minutes	Every cipher and every count checked by script; four answers that could be guessed without solving were fixed.
Read-alouds and graphic stories	10 to 12 minutes each	Two stories plus a draw-it	Word counts re-checked.
Songs and movement	1 to 3 minutes each	A five-piece "Hackles Stage" session	Two songs had lines that did not fit their tune; fixed.
Puppet show	Short show about 10 minutes (Scenes 1, 2, 5, 8)	Full show 18 to 20 minutes (K-2 version about 13)	The first draft said "12 minutes" for what is really 18 to 20.
Bingo	K-2 to blackout about 10 minutes; 3-12 one line about 8 minutes	Full Bingo three rounds about 22 to 25 minutes	A K-2 line arrives after 3 or 4 clues; a 5 x 5 blackout needs almost all 30 clues.
Jokes and teasers	1 to 2 minutes each	A 10-minute Riddle Café	All teaser answers checked.
Hackles Day	12-minute stations	Half-day: 2 sessions of 6 slots	Both rotation tables verified: no clashes, every group visits all 12 stations.

HOW GAMES MAP TO THE LESSONS

Every game says which lesson it reinforces. Use this table to pick a game for the week.

IF THIS WEEK'S LESSON IS...	PLAY THIS
K-2 L1 My Tell-Someone Team; 3-5 L1 Help Ladder; 6-8 L1 Help Ladder	Hackles Trail (Ladder spaces), Role-Play Library R1-R4, "Tell-Someone Song"
Passwords and passphrases (K-2 L2, 3-5 L2, 6-8 L2, 9-12 L2)	Mission: Quiet Door vault missions, "Passphrase Rap", Bingo (Lock It squares)
Scams and fakes (K-2 L3/L8, 3-5 L3/L8, 6-8 L3, 9-12 L3)	Spot the Fishy, giveaway missions, puppet show
Oops recovery (K-2 L4, 3-5 L10, 6-8 L2 Oops plan, 9-12 L2/L10)	Hackles Trail (Fix-It Bridge), "Oops Is Okay" read-alouds, Role-Play Library R9-R11
Privacy and sharing (K-2 L5, 3-5 L5, 6-8 L4, 9-12 L4)	Spot the Fishy (Pause and Ask cards), Trail (Share Meadow), read-aloud "Pip Picks a Shell"
Game chat and group chat (3-5 L6/L7, 6-8 L9, 9-12 L8)	Group-chat missions, Role-Play Library R12-R16, graphic story "The Chat That Got Loud"
Fakes and synthetic media (K-2 L8, 6-8 L8, 9-12 L6)	Deepfake detective missions, Spot the Fishy 6-12 deck

IF THIS WEEK'S LESSON IS...	PLAY THIS
Pressure and threats (6-8 L7, 9-12 L5/L7)	Spot the Fishy "STOP-SAVE-TELL-REPORT" cards (optional), role-play R17-R18. Read the safety notes below first.

The Hackles Routine (every game uses it)

STEP	SAY	HAND SIGNAL
Hackles up?	"Hackles up?"	Hand raised and brushed up the back of the neck
Pause	"Pause."	Flat palm up like a stop sign (Pause Palm)
Check	"Check."	Fingers to eyes (K-2) or circle fingers like a magnifying glass (3-5), then look around for a grown-up or look for a second source
Tell	"Tell."	Hand on heart, then reach out (Tell Wave)

Two promises, said out loud at the start of every game:

- 1. A false alarm is fine.** Saying "my hackles are up" about something that turns out to be real is never wrong, never silly, and never costs a point you care about.
- 2. It is never your fault.** If a game card is about someone who got tricked, they did nothing wrong. The tricker did. And they told someone, and it got fixed.

For grades 6-12: the Response Drill is **STOP · SAVE · TELL · REPORT**. It appears in the Spot the Fishy 6-12 deck, the Trail 6-12 events and the 6-8 and 9-12 missions. The **Help Ladder** (Yourself, a friend, a trusted adult, a reporting channel) and the **Next-Rung Rule** ("If the first person you tell does not help, you are not done. Tell the next person.") appear in every band's Trail game.

The Crew (who is who)

CHARACTER	STRAND	ROLE IN THE GAMES	LOOK (FROM THE ART STYLE GUIDE V2)
Hackle	Hero, all strands	The "tingly uh-oh" detector. Host of every K-5 game. In 6-12 materials appears only as a small corner icon, never in dialogue.	Baby hedgehog, pale-yellow quills tipped tangerine that stand up with a tiny "!" sparkle (Hackles Up) and lie flat when calm (Hackles Down). They/them.
Latch	Lock It	Passwords and passphrases	Friendly round mint padlock with a keyhole smile
Peeper	Spot It	Scams, fakes, clues	Big-eyed sky-blue magnifying-glass/owl-ish critter
Pip	Share Smart	Privacy	Little coral hermit-crab/snail who decides what to show
Buddy	Safe People	Trusted adults	Gentle grape-colored bear/dog-ish pal with a heart badge
Ember	Kind & Well	Kindness, wellbeing, screen balance	Warm teal flame/sun sprite
Fixit	Fix It	Telling, recovery, Oops	Tangerine helper robot with a toolbelt and bandages
The Too-Good Box ("Gifty")	The silly trickster	Appears in the Trail game and some stories as a cartoon shiny gift box with a tiny fish hook and a big grin. Never scary, never mean, always a little ridiculous, never sad or lonely, and voiced by an adult only. [ART REQUEST: Gifty art is not yet in kit/09_Art/characters/ ; ask the art team for gifty.png .]	Gold box, sparkly bow, a hook sticking out of the bow like a curl

Note on Hackle's color: early drafts of the Brand and Rename Rules and the Teacher Guides described Hackle as navy; those were corrected in the Round 1 and Round 2 reviews to match the Art Style Guide v2: Hackle is a baby hedgehog with pale-yellow, tangerine-tipped quills; navy is for outlines and text only. All art notes in this pack follow v2.

The human kids (kept per band; casts are not merged):

- **K-2:** Maya (6), Omar (7), Lily (5), Dev (6). Trusted adults: Maya's dads, Omar's Teta, Lily's sister Rosa and parents, Dev's grandmother and big cousin.
- **3-5 "Hands-On Hackers":** Mateo, Amara, Priya, Kenji, Sam. Trusted adults: Ms. Alvarez (counselor), Coach Dee, Mr. Okafor, Grandma Whitfeather, Aunt Lin.
- **6-8 "Case Files":** Jordan, Remy, Anika, Nia and the other case-file characters from the Teacher Guide. No mascots in dialogue.

- **9-12:** no recurring characters; plain, respectful scenarios.

Ground rules for every game in this pack

1. **Everyone plays; nobody is out.** There is no elimination in any game. Mistakes earn "Learning Pearls", "Oops-path" moves or "Next-Rung" moves, never penalties that sit on one child. When a trick slips through in a game, it is shown as something that can happen to anyone, never as a choice someone should have made differently.
2. **Teams, not individuals, carry the score.** Mixed teams; the score belongs to the team or the whole class. The class always has a way to win together.
3. **Nobody plays the bad actor.** Children and teens never role-play the scammer, the pressurer, the groomer, the extortioner, or the person who makes fakes. In K-5, the trickster is a cardboard Too-Good Box voiced by the teacher or drawn from a card. In 6-12, trickery lives on cards the class reads and analyzes. If a role-play needs "the pushy voice," the **teacher or a printed script card** supplies it.
4. **No real brands, apps, people, or accounts.** Scenarios say "a game chat," "a video app," "a shop site." Make-believe link addresses end in **.example** (a placeholder, standing in for .com). Never use a real address on a card.
5. **Defense only.** No game teaches how to build a scam, break into an account, groom a person, extort a person, or make a fake image. Games teach recognizing, pausing, checking, telling, saving, reporting and recovering.
6. **Always an out.** Any player can touch a green **Pass card** (printed with the word PASS and a check mark) or say "Pass, please" and sit out a card with no questions asked. This matches the Pass cards in the 6-8 Reproducibles. Offer it often.
7. **Disclosure.** Games sometimes bring up real feelings. If a child says something that suggests they or someone else is being hurt, threatened, or tricked, stop the game kindly and follow the "If a student discloses" box in your Teacher Guide and the Disclosure and Incident Guide. Do not promise secrecy. Promise help.

8. **Heavy-card flag (H).** Some 6-12 cards touch pressure, threats, or fake images of real people. They are marked **(H)**. Remove all H cards for classes where families opted out of the sensitive lessons (6-8 L7 and L8; 9-12 L5, L6 and L7), or when a counselor advises. Games work fine without them. No card in this pack involves sexual content; the sensitive lessons handle that, with their own safeguards.
9. **Teach the behavior, not the app.** The skills stay true when the apps change.
10. **Fun is a safety feature.** Kids who laugh at a scam are kids who recognize it later. Be silly. Use voices. Cheer for pausing.
11. **Never rely on color alone.** About 1 child in 12 boys and 1 in 200 girls has a color-vision difference [VERIFY]. Every color-coded card, token or envelope also has a **shape, a word and a symbol**.
12. **The trickster is a silly trick, not a sad stranger.** Do not give Gifty a sympathetic story. Real tricky messages are never sorry, and the lesson is always to pause.

TEACHER WORDS THAT WORK

SAY THIS	NOT THIS
"Great noticing!"	"Wrong."
"Hackles up is never wrong to say."	"That one was obvious."
"That trick fools grown-ups too."	"How could you fall for that?"
"Let's find the clue together."	"Read it again, you missed it."
"You told someone. That is the brave part."	"You should have told sooner."

CHOOSE YOUR PLAY MODE

Every game has a **10-minute mode** (a warm-up or station) and a **30-minute mode** (a full lesson extension). The Pack never needs more than paper, scissors, pencils, a timer, and a few envelopes.

MODE	WHEN TO USE	TYPICAL GROUP
10-minute "Quick Catch"	Lesson warm-up, indoor recess, last 10 minutes of a period, early-finisher station	Whole class or table groups
30-minute "Full Adventure"	Lesson extension, assembly, Hackles Day station, substitute-teacher day, family night	Whole class, 4-6 teams

PRINTING AND CUTTING GUIDE

- Cards: print the card lists as 2-column tables on card stock; the "back" column is the answer side. Cut after printing. Or write each card on an index card.
- Boards: build from the grids in the files using a sheet of poster paper, masking tape, and colored markers. For coloring-page and classroom-poster versions use the Art Style Guide (thick outlines, flat colors, big shapes).
- Color paper suggestions: Hackle sunshine yellow; Latch mint; Peeper sky; Pip coral; Buddy grape; Ember teal; Fixit tangerine. Color is **decoration only**: give every colored item a shape, a word and a symbol too.
- Make a "Pass card" for every child on green paper with the word PASS and a check mark.
- Each file has its own **Printables checklist** that names exactly what to print and cut, with counts and the art files to use from [kit/09_Art/characters/](#) (hackle_*.png, latch.png, peeper.png, pip.png, buddy.png, kindle.png, fixit.png, crew_group.png) and the 6-12 geometric icons ([kit/09_Art/icon_*.png](#)).

ACCESSIBILITY CHECKLIST (USE FOR EVERY GAME)

- Read every card aloud. Never make a child read in front of the class unless they choose to.
- Offer response by pointing, hand signal, card **shape**, or a spoken word. No response needs writing.
- Pair readers with non-readers by choice, not by announcement.
- For Deaf or hard-of-hearing students: use the written card and hand signals; Lily's "help" sign appears in K-2 materials [VERIFY with a Deaf educator].
- For students who find noise hard: use the "Quiet Door whisper" variants in the missions; use waving hands (not cheering) as the applause.
- For wheelchair users and mobility needs: every movement break has a seated version; the Trail and Hackles Day layouts need 36-inch (about 90 cm) wide paths [VERIFY local accessibility guidance].

- Avoid timers that cause anxiety: use the visible timer for pace, but never end a game with a "you lost" message.
- **Color-vision difference:** shapes, words and symbols on every colored item (see rule 11).
- **English language learners:** read each card twice; a helper may repeat it in the home language; answers by card, signal or pointing; avoid idioms or explain them in one sentence.
- **Low vision or blind:** large print, read aloud, raised or felt markers, a partner who describes the board.
- **Motor needs:** answers can be spoken, pointed or tapped; a partner may move a token or cover a square.
- **Anxiety or past experiences:** every game has Pass cards; nobody answers alone; preview heavy content with your counselor.

WHAT KIDS WILL SAY (AND WHAT TO ANSWER)

- **"That was so obvious!"** "Yes! That is exactly what Peeper wants you to say after you've practiced. Let's tell the next card to the person who needs it."
- **"My uncle fell for that."** "Lots of grown-ups do. They are tricky. It is never anyone's fault. What did they do after?"
- **"Can we play again?"** Yes. That is the whole point.

PACK-WIDE PRINTABLES MASTER LIST (COUNTS AT A GLANCE)

Details, art files and cut instructions are in each file's Printables checklist.

FILE	WHAT TO PRINT	COUNT
01 Spot the Fishy	One deck (K-5 or 6-12), answer cards, Pass cards, Pond Mat plus Lagoon	66 cards + 18 answer cards + 30 Pass cards
02 The Hackles Trail	Board, one band's cards, answer cards, jar, coin, ladder strip	58 cards + 18 answer cards + 30 Pass cards + board
03 Mission: Quiet Door	One mission's cards and envelopes (see the table in file 03)	12 to 30 cards + 3 or 4 correct envelopes + decoys + 18 Ask Buddy cards
04 Read-alouds	Story pages, signal poster, Trusted Hand poster	1 copy per story + 2 posters
05 Songs	Lyric posters, Gifty offer cards	8 posters + 8 cards
06 Puppets and role-plays	Puppets, Gifty hats, call cards, Message and script cards, Observer checklists	8 puppets + 4 to 7 hats + 6 call cards + about 30 role-play cards

FILE	WHAT TO PRINT	COUNT
07 Bingo, Passport, Badges	6 cards per band, clue lists, Passports, stamps, badges, certificates	14 cards + 28 Passports + about 85 badges + 28 certificates (class of 28)
08 Jokes	Joke cards, posters, Joke Jar slips	30 cards + 30 slips
09 Hackles Day	Station signs, rotation tables, per-station sets	12 signs + 2 tables + per-station sets